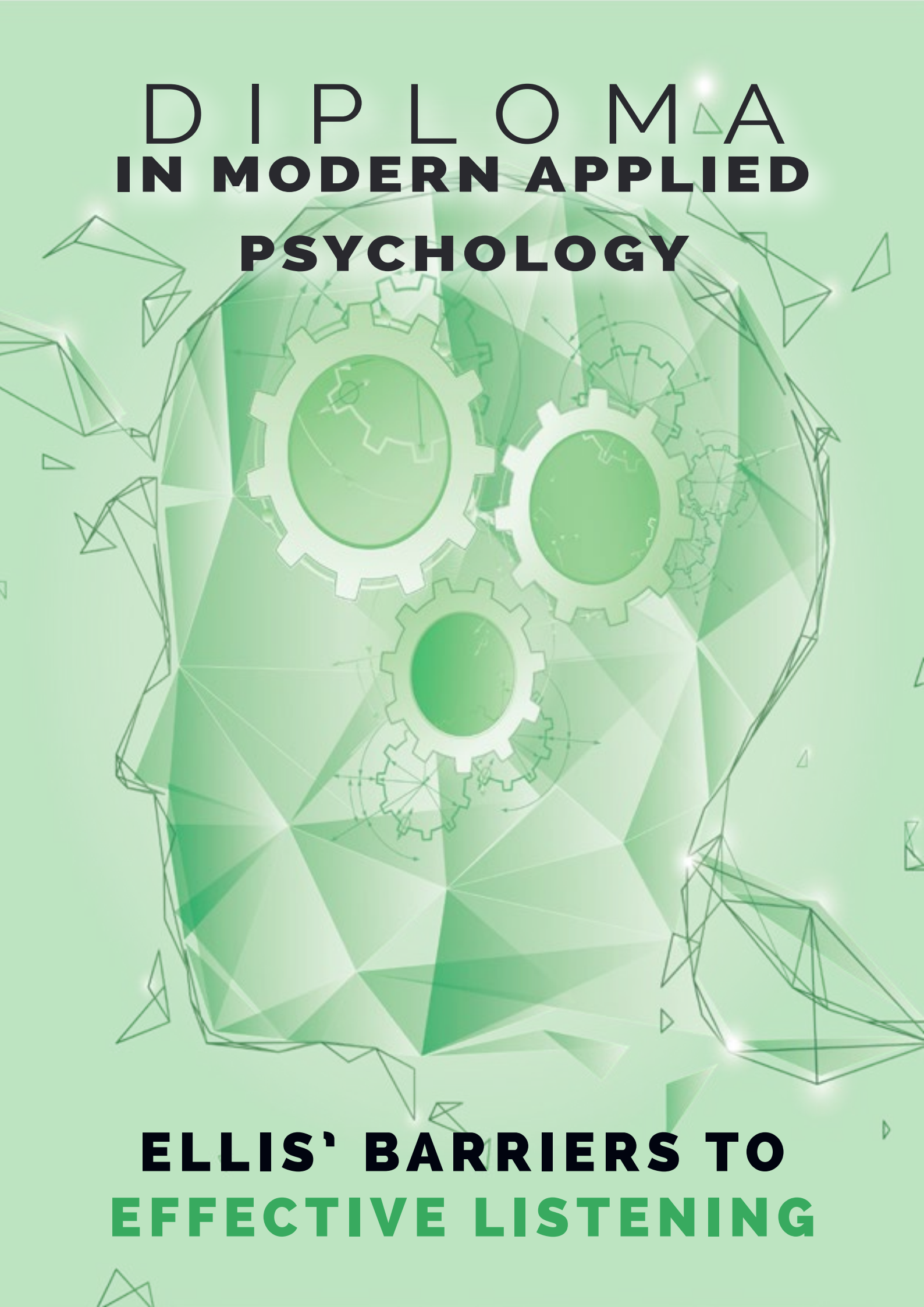


# DIPLOMA IN MODERN APPLIED PSYCHOLOGY



## ELLIS' BARRIERS TO EFFECTIVE LISTENING

# ELLIS' BARRIERS TO EFFECTIVE LISTENING

Many things get in the way of our listening. To become more effective listeners, we must become aware of our barriers and bad habits. These include:

## **1. Listening to more than one voice at a time (us and them)**

Prioritising what someone is actually saying to you is tricky in this noisy and busy world. We're always receiving emails, texts, phone calls and notifications when we're out and about, or even just at home with a friend, family member or partner. When we are distracted with all the other noises around us, we can fall into a bad habit of listening to our own thoughts more than what's being said to us. Because of this, we fall into a trap of listening more to give a response than to listening to hear and understand what someone is saying: this isn't a dialogue, but a disguised monologue.

## **2. Finding the communicator attractive and over-connecting with them**

Attraction isn't always about physical appearance: it can also relate to what is being communicated. Conversations can open us up to emotional, physical, and spiritual attraction and chemistry with another person. Whilst it's needless to say that this is incredibly inappropriate in a professional context, it's also a bad habit to fall into regularly because it usually leads to daydreaming or fantasising about the person you're talking to, rather than listening to what they have to say.

## **3. Finding the communicator unattractive and disconnecting with them**

On the opposite side of the scale, being put off by someone for who they are, what they believe in, how they look or what they're saying is abhorrent behaviour, but all of us are guilty of this to some degree. Whether it's someone's style of clothing, teeth, bad breath, skin, weight, beliefs, opinions, accent or hygiene, disconnecting with someone on a superficial or undeveloped basis is inconsiderate and the sign of a poor listener. We need to learn how to fundamentally understand people by making peace with who people are and the imperfections that come with them. Everyone deserves to be heard and understood first and foremost.

## **4. Driven more by 'being right' than listening, hearing and understanding**

We all operate out of a fixed set of beliefs, but this behaviour tends to show itself more frequently when it comes to those who operate from the rational side of their mind the most. Our beliefs are a set of ideas we invested in when we were younger and built our lives upon. When we're rigid in our thinking and are unwilling to acknowledge there is any degree of truth outside our realm of knowledge, life becomes more about 'right and wrong' than understanding. Wisdom evolves from taking the time to compare what we know with that outside our realm of understanding.

## **5. Over-identifying with an idea instead of 'trying it on for size'**

This is something which happens with those who operate more out of the emotional part of their mind. When we cling onto ideas and information as an ultimate truth, our small thinking prevents us from understanding more. Sometimes, people will spend more energy defending the little that they think they know rather than investing that energy into deepening their understanding and allowing that understanding to be challenged. They end up rejecting anything which threatens or contradicts their frame of reference, cutting off the communication entirely and ceasing to listen. Maturity is about developing a more grounded set of world views and beliefs which allow us to understand others better.



# ELLIS' BARRIERS TO EFFECTIVE LISTENING

## 6. Trying to remember information instead of applying it to the self

The modern education system promotes the idea that learning consists of digesting and regurgitating information for specific periods of time. Let's face it: most of us studied like crazy at school to try and pass exams, but we all forgot the information we crammed into our heads within a few weeks after our exams. Growing the rational part of our mind doesn't help us grow our relational skills unless we apply the knowledge to ourselves and grow through the process. Applying principles to ourselves is a more effective learning method than trying to remember everything.

## 7. Sympathising with someone instead of empathising with them

Sympathising is a superficial form of empathy. When we extend our sympathy to someone, we're doing nothing for the other person (except, perhaps, feeding an unhealthy need they have). Empathy, however, is when we extend ourselves to ensure we understand another person's experience as much as feasibly possible. Empathy seeks to understand another person's perspective and uncover how their experience is holding them back mentally and emotionally.

## 8. Allowing prejudices and preferences to undermine the learning process

When we allow our own prejudices to undermine the learning process, it comes at the cost of our life experiences. For example, say you were meeting up with an old best mate who you hadn't seen in years and you start fantasising about the meet-up. You've told all your other friends about how great this old best mate of yours is: how you've kept in contact through texting and they're always so considerate and generous and they're your best friend ever, despite not having seen each other in nearly a decade.

Finally, the day comes when you meet up for drinks and the two of you have no chemistry. You both don't know what to say to each other and you find they have some mannerisms which irk you. You come away from the evening heartbroken and disappointed and you subconsciously blame your friend for not being as good as you thought they were. Disappointment only ever arises when our expectations are not met. When we put too much emphasis on meeting our expectations, we overlook and ignore all the lessons and experiences we are going through which are worthwhile in themselves.

## 9. Having preconceived ideas or expectations about what you will hear

This concept is very similar to the previous one except it involves listening and selective hearing. For example, people with a negative self-image and low confidence will go around with a heightened sense of awareness to criticism and negativity coming their way. When they are critiqued or perhaps confronted in any shape or form, they will amplify it in their own mind to be bigger or more serious than it was. If they get called into their boss' office, they prepare themselves for a scolding and come out feeling scolded when all they'd been given was gentle constructive criticism.

The same can happen in reverse: a parent overlooks what a teacher tells them about their child's bad behaviour because they went into parent's evening expecting only to hear adoring praise of their beloved child, and a person madly in love doesn't hear their partner's unfair and excessive snide comments because they only listen blindly for the good. This can affect modern applied psychologists who are later on in their career, feel like they've 'heard it all before' and expect the same backstory and emotional responses from clients dealing with similar (or identical) problems.



## ELLIS' BARRIERS TO EFFECTIVE LISTENING

### 10. Being distracted by obvious external factors

It's easy to allow ourselves to be distracted by things we don't need to be focussing on such as the cars outside, a conversation happening at another table, a dog barking, your phone vibrating in your pocket or the smell of some delicious food passing by. People will notice when another person is distracted when they're speaking to them and will close themselves off more in response. The second you demonstrate you're a distracted listener, you lose the trust of the person speaking and they will withhold more intimate details from the conversation and keep it surface level. We can't allow the world going on around us to impact our conversations with others, especially in a helping environment.

### 11. Listening more to what might be said instead of actively listening to accurately hear what is actually being said

People who are more rationally minded don't believe in the significance of speech which is simplistic and straightforward; they prefer to invest in complexity and the unfolding of conversation. As a more exaggerated but illustrative example, these people may hear a sentence such as 'the curtains were blue' and ask the person to extrapolate as to why they shared this information by asking 'are you saying my curtains should be blue?' In other words, these people add meaning onto what you're saying either by reading too much into it or by imposing their insecurities, judgements or perspectives onto it. Sometimes there really isn't any more to a sentence than there is.

Whilst you may argue that a compliment was a backhanded one which was insinuating something else, or someone's remark was passive-aggressive despite being polite to the outside world, but there's little to no benefit in imposing meaning onto speech because we'll never be in a position to deny or confirm our suspicions. We can't access the recesses of someone's psyche and we can't read minds - we can only go based on what we hear. Of course, we must always ask for clarification if we are confused by what a person is saying, but imposing deep meaning into a dialogue overcomplicates a situation to the point that it can be deemed confrontational and dismissive of what a person is saying.

